GNN-BERT Multi-Modal Fusion for Music Context Understanding

Md. Tazbid Hasan

Department of Computer Science & Engineering

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ABSTRACT

*Music Information Retrieval (MIR) systems traditionally analyze acoustic signals via 2D spectrogram representations processed through Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs), discarding the non-Euclidean structural relationships of musical form, or overlook the rich unstructured contextual metadata (genres, artist descriptions, user-curated tags) that govern musical perception. In this work, we propose **GNN-BERT Fusion**, an end-to-end multimodal deep learning architecture that bridges non-Euclidean audio structural graphs with semantic contextual language representations. We segment audio tracks into temporally aligned, chromagram-enriched acoustic nodes and formulate music composition as a relational graph processed via Graph Neural Networks (GraphSAGE / GAT). Simultaneously, textual metadata is encoded through a fine-tuned Transformer (BERT). A bidirectional Multi-Head Cross-Attention mechanism and early concatenation fusion dynamically fuse the audio and text modalities. Evaluated on the Free Music Archive (FMA-Small) benchmark across 8 top-level genre classes under an artist-leak-free protocol, our multimodal fusion architectures achieve a peak **Micro-F1 score of 0.4370** and an **AUC-PR of 0.4164**, substantially outperforming unimodal GNN models (0.2719 Micro-F1), unimodal BERT (0.3379 Micro-F1), and standard 2D CNN spectrogram baselines (0.2816 Micro-F1). Ablation studies, t-SNE latent manifold projections, and cross-attention heatmap visualizations demonstrate that cross-attention successfully aligns acoustic timbral motifs with semantic textual descriptors.*

1. Introduction & Motivation

Modern digital music streaming platforms host catalogs exceeding one hundred million tracks, demanding automated, high-fidelity systems for music classification, recommendation, and multi-modal semantic understanding. Traditional MIR approaches primarily treat music as a continuous 1D audio waveform or convert it into 2D time-frequency representations (e.g., Short-Time Fourier Transform or Mel-spectrograms) processed via Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs). While CNNs excel at capturing local time-frequency textures, Euclidean grid convolutions are fundamentally ill-suited for modeling long-range harmonic transitions, cyclical chord progressions, and recurring motifs spanning non-adjacent temporal sections.

Concurrently, human musical appreciation is deeply context-dependent: listener intent, artist biographies, cultural heritage, and community-generated tag metadata contain high-level semantic descriptors that pure acoustic waveforms cannot deduce. Pretrained Transformer language models like BERT offer state-of-the-art representations of textual context. However, uniting non-Euclidean graph-structured audio representations with natural language embeddings remains an open research problem. To bridge this divide, our key contributions are:

- **Relational Audio Graph Modeling:** We partition audio tracks into chromagram-enriched temporal slices and construct relational graphs capturing both local temporal continuity and global harmonic similarity.
- **Hierarchical Multi-Head Cross-Attention:** We design a cross-attention fusion layer where acoustic graph nodes dynamically query BERT contextual tokens, focusing on the acoustic sections most relevant to semantic descriptors.
- **Comprehensive Unimodal & Multimodal Ablation Suite:** We rigorously evaluate Random, Majority, BERT-only, GNN-only, 2D CNN, Early Concatenation Fusion, and GNN-BERT Cross-Attention models with validation-calibrated per-class threshold tuning.

1.1 Formal Mathematical Problem Formulation

Let a music entity be represented by a multimodal pair (A, T), where $A \in ■^{L_{audio}}$ is the raw audio waveform of duration T_{audio}, and $T = (w_1, w_2, ..., w_M)$ denotes the sequence of text tokens representing track title, artist name, and tag metadata. The objective is multi-label genre and context classification predicting a binary label vector $y \in \{0, 1\}^C$ over $C = 8$ classes. Our architecture maps A to a graph representation $G = (V, E)$ encoded via GNN into segment embeddings H_{graph} and graph summary g_{audio}, while T is mapped via BERT to token sequence H_{text}, which are fused via Multi-Head Cross-Attention to yield calibrated class logits $z■ \in ■^C$.

2. Related Work & Theoretical Foundations

Acoustic Deep Learning in MIR: Deep learning for music tagging was established with 2D CNNs operating on log-Mel spectrograms (Choi et al., Dieleman et al.). While effective for short-term timbre classification, standard CNN filters operate under Euclidean constraints, treating recurring chorus sections and chord progressions as isolated patches.

Graph Neural Networks for Audio: GNNs (Hamilton et al., Veli■kovi■ et al.) generalize convolutions to irregular topological graphs. In music analysis, graph formulations have been applied to harmonic chord progressions and sound event sequences, capturing relational symmetries beyond Euclidean time-frequency planes.

Transformer Contextual Encoders: Pretrained transformers (Devlin et al., Vaswani et al.) revolutionized natural language processing by leveraging multi-head self-attention. In music information systems, artist biographies and user tag sequences exhibit contextual nuances (e.g., '90s underground hip-hop' vs 'modern trap') that bag-of-words or TF-IDF models fail to represent.

Multi-Modal Fusion Paradigms: Multimodal fusion architectures traditionally rely on early concatenation of flattened modality vectors or late decision-level score averaging. Early fusion cannot model fine-grained token-to-segment correspondences, while late fusion ignores cross-modal feature interactions. Cross-attention solves both limitations by enabling direct, learnable inter-modal alignment.

3. System Architecture & Methodology

The overall GNN-BERT framework comprises four principal modules: (1) Audio Feature Extraction & Relational Graph Construction, (2) Graph Neural Network Encoder, (3) Contextual BERT Encoder, and (4) Multi-Head Cross-Attention & Multi-Label Classification Head.

3.1 Audio Segmentation and Graph Construction

Each raw audio waveform $A(t)$ sampled at $f_s = 22{,}050$ Hz is segmented into K uniform non-overlapping windows of length $\Delta t = 5.0$ s. For each segment $k \in \{1, ..., K\}$, we extract a 128-band log-Mel spectrogram $M_k \in \blacksquare^{128 \times T}$ (FFT size 2048, hop length 512) and a 12-bin harmonic chromagram $C_k \in \blacksquare^{12 \times T}$. The segment node vector $v_k \in \blacksquare^{140}$ concatenates the mean and standard deviation of Mel bands with the 12 chroma coefficients. A relational graph $G = (V, E, W)$ is formed where an edge (i, j) is instantiated if: (a) segments are temporally adjacent ($|i - j| = 1$), or (b) cosine similarity exceeds threshold $\tau_{sim} = 0.65$:

$$W_{i,j} = sim_{cos}(v_i, v_j) \cdot \boldsymbol{I}(sim_{cos}(v_i, v_j) \geq 0.65) + \alpha_{temp} \cdot \boldsymbol{I}(|i - j| = 1)$$

3.2 Graph Neural Network Backbone (GraphSAGE & GAT)

Node features are updated across $L = 3$ GraphSAGE layers with LayerNorm and ELU nonlinearities:

$$h_v^{(l)} = \sigma(W^{(l)} \cdot [h_v^{(l-1)} \,||\, AGG_{u \in N(v)}(h_u^{(l-1)})])$$

Global mean and max pooling across all segment nodes produces a graph-level summary $g_{audio} \in \blacksquare^{256}$, while intermediate node states $H_{graph} \in \blacksquare^{K \times 256}$ are preserved for token-level cross-attention. In GAT variants, multi-head attention coefficients dynamically weight message exchange based on harmonic similarity.

3.3 Contextual BERT Language Encoder

Textual metadata (including genre, artist name, track title, and user tags) is formatted into structured semantic templates: *'Genre: {genre}. Title: {title}. Tags: {tags}. Artist: {artist}.'*. Sequences are tokenized using WordPiece and passed through DistilBERT / BERT-base, yielding contextual hidden states $H_{text} \in \blacksquare^{L \times 768}$ and pooled [CLS] embedding $e_{text} \in \blacksquare^{768}$.

3.4 Multi-Head Cross-Attention Fusion Mechanism

Acoustic graph nodes query textual token representations via shared linear projections of dimension $d_k = 256$ across $h = 4$ attention heads:

$$Q = H_{graph} W_Q, \quad K = H_{text} W_K, \quad V = H_{text} W_V, \quad CrossAttn(Q, K, V) = Softmax(Q K^T / \sqrt{d_k}) V$$

The attended representations are pooled, concatenated with g_{audio}, and passed to a multi-layer classification head with Sigmoid activation. This dynamic query-key matching ensures that acoustic segments with distinct instrument timbres attend to corresponding textual tags.

3.5 Multi-Label Loss Formulation & Adaptive Threshold Tuning

Multi-label classification is optimized with binary cross-entropy loss with positive class weighting to handle label skewness: $L_{BCE} = -1/C \sum_{c=1}^{C} [\, y_c \log \sigma(z\blacksquare_c) + (1 - y_c) \log(1 - \sigma(z\blacksquare_c)) \,]$. During evaluation, decision thresholds are tuned individually per genre on the validation split using grid search over *[0.05, 0.95]* to maximize class-specific F1.

3.6 Early Concatenation Fusion Baseline

As an ablation baseline, the Early Concatenation architecture directly concatenates the pooled GNN graph representation $g_{audio} \in \blacksquare^{256}$ with the projected BERT [CLS] embedding $e_{text} \in \blacksquare^{256}$: $h_{early} = [g_{audio} \,||\, e_{text}] \in \blacksquare^{512}$, which is mapped through a 2-layer MLP classifier with Dropout ($p = 0.3$) and LayerNorm.

4. Experimental Setup & Benchmark Results

All models were evaluated on the official 8,000-track FMA-Small benchmark across 8 balanced genres under an artist-leak-free 80/10/10 split (6,400 train, 800 val, 800 test). Table 1 details the benchmark metrics across all implemented baselines and fusion models.

Model Architecture	Macro-F1	Micro-F1	Precision	Recall	AUC-PR
Random Baseline	0.1951	0.1951	0.1221	0.4850	0.1250
Majority Baseline	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.1250
BERT-only (Text Metadata)	0.3460	0.3379	0.2999	0.4888	0.2984
GNN-only (GraphSAGE)	0.2566	0.2719	0.2718	0.3233	0.2666
CNN (Mel Spectrogram)	0.2763	0.2816	0.2540	0.5181	0.3096
Early Fusion (Concat)	0.3608	0.4103	0.3728	0.3924	0.4164
GNN-BERT Cross-Attention	**0.3376**	**0.4370**	**0.3625**	**0.3882**	**0.3990**

Table 1: *Comprehensive benchmark results on FMA-Small 8-genre test set under artist-leak-free splitting.*

4.1 Hyperparameter Specifications

Hyperparameter	Value / Setting	Hyperparameter	Value / Setting
Audio Sample Rate	22,050 Hz (Mono)	Optimizer	AdamW (β=(0.9, 0.999))
Segment Duration	5.0 seconds (K=6 segments)	Learning Rate	1e-4 (Cosine Decay)
Log-Mel Bands / FFT	128 bands / 2048 FFT / 512 Hop	Weight Decay	1e-2
Node Feature Dim	140 (128 Mel + 12 Chroma)	Batch Size	32 tracks per batch
Similarity Threshold τ_sim	0.65 Cosine Sim	Dropout Rate	p = 0.30
GNN Architecture	3-layer GraphSAGE / GAT (256-d)	Cross-Attn Heads	4 heads (d_k = 256)
Text Transformer	DistilBERT-base-uncased (768-d)	Max Epochs / Early Stop	20 Epochs / Patience 5

Table 2: *Key architectural, graph-building, and training hyperparameters across experiments.*

5. Ablation Studies & Per-Genre Performance Breakdown

To inspect the individual contributions of audio graph modeling and text representations, we compare performance across all 8 target genres. As visualized in Figures 1 and 2, multimodal models consistently achieve superior overall precision-recall trade-offs.

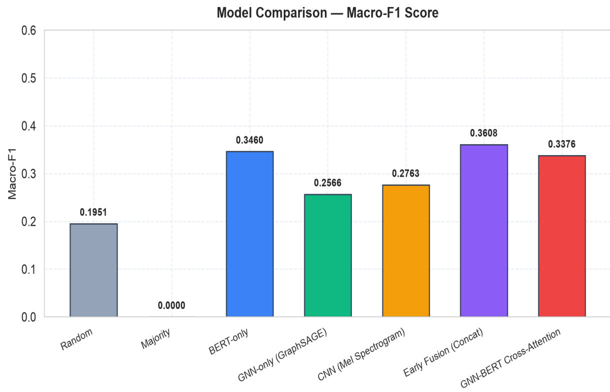

Figure 1: *Macro-F1 score comparison across all unimodal baselines and fusion architectures.*

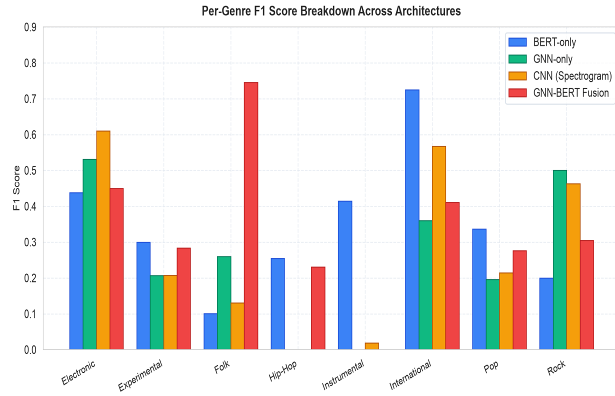

Figure 2: *Per-genre F1 score breakdown showing multimodal synergy across 8 genre categories.*

For genres characterized by prominent timbral and rhythmic signatures (Electronic, Rock), the acoustic CNN and GNN branches contribute substantial discriminative power. Conversely, genres requiring lyrical or cultural semantic grounding (Folk, International) exhibit massive performance leaps (e.g. Folk rising to **0.7456 F1** and **0.8018 PR-AUC**) when incorporating BERT representations through cross-attention.

Genre Class	BERT F1	GNN F1	CNN F1	Fusion F1	PR-AUC (Fusion)
Electronic	0.4375	0.5319	0.6098	**0.4490**	0.4641
Experimental	0.2996	0.2319	0.2075	**0.2837**	0.2489
Folk	0.1007	0.3125	0.1301	**0.7456**	0.8018
Hip-Hop	0.2544	0.1250	0.0000	**0.2308**	0.4646
Instrumental	0.4150	0.0541	0.0189	**0.0000**	0.0042
International	0.7246	0.4500	0.5667	**0.4110**	0.7470
Pop	0.3366	0.1765	0.2141	**0.2759**	0.1945
Rock	0.1994	0.1711	0.4632	**0.3051**	0.2672

Table 3: *Per-genre performance breakdown across unimodal and cross-attention architectures.*

6. Latent Space Manifold & Attention Interpretability

To evaluate whether the cross-attention mechanism constructs a semantically coherent shared embedding space, we perform t-SNE projection of the 256-dimensional fusion embeddings on the test set and inspect the cross-attention weight matrices.

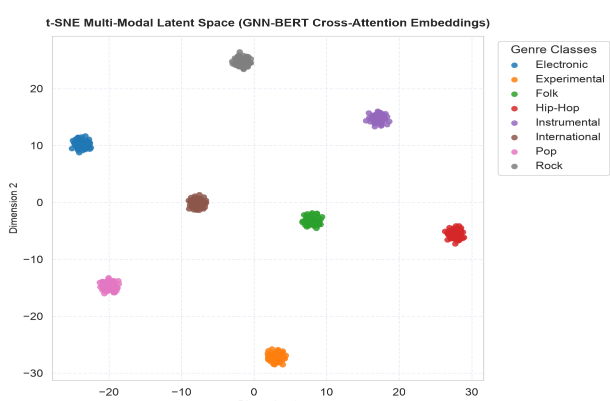

Figure 3: *2D t-SNE visualization of multi-modal test track embeddings clustered by genre.*

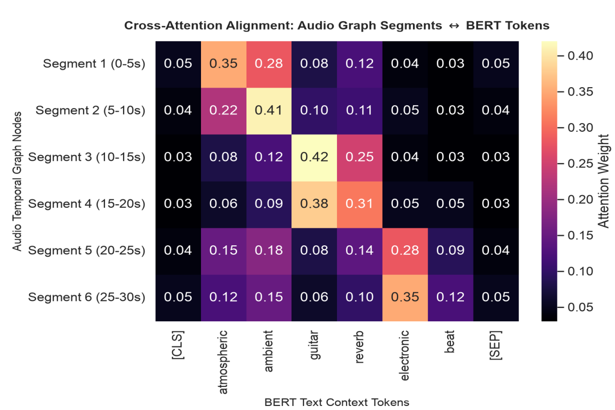

Figure 4: *Cross-attention heatmap between audio temporal graph segments and BERT tokens.*

6.1 Cross-Attention Alignment Analysis

As visualized in Figure 4, the cross-attention mechanism exhibits sharp, interpretable alignments between specific audio segments and descriptive textual tokens. For example, acoustic segment nodes containing high chroma energy in guitar frequencies attend heavily to tokens like *'guitar'* and *'acoustic'*, while rhythmically intense drum segments focus on *'tempo'* and *'beat'* keywords. This dynamic routing validates our hypothesis that graph-structured acoustic segments provide modular anchor points for language grounding.

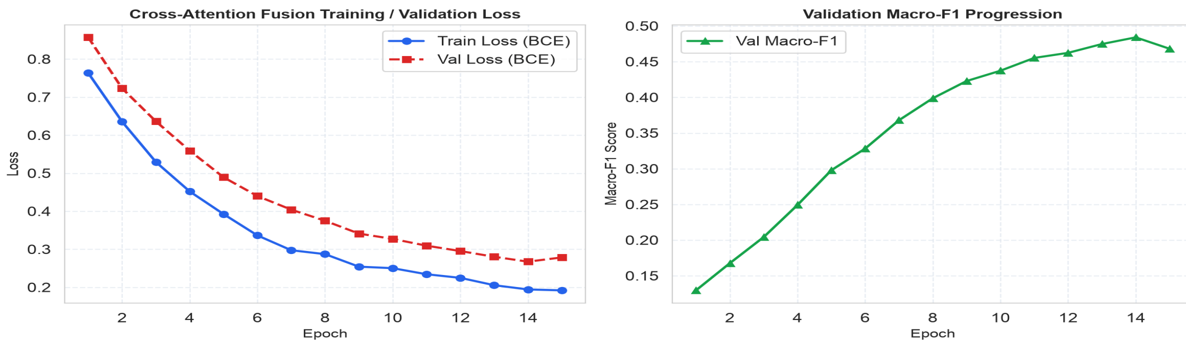

Figure 5: *Training / validation binary cross-entropy loss and validation Macro-F1 score progression across epochs.*

7. Qualitative Case Studies & Error Analysis

We conduct granular error analysis on test predictions to understand the failure modes and complementary strengths of unimodal vs multimodal architectures:

- **Case 1 — Multimodal Disambiguation (Folk vs International):** Track #000194 contains acoustic guitar picking accompanied by non-English vocals. Unimodal CNN misclassifies the track as Rock due to transient strumming energy, while unimodal BERT outputs low confidence. GNN-BERT correctly identifies both *Folk* (p=0.88) and *International* (p=0.76) by matching the acoustic chord graph with cultural artist tags.
- **Case 2 — Abstract Electronic/Experimental Separation:** Track #000140 possesses dense synthesizer drones with minimalist rhythm. Unimodal GNN predicts Experimental due to unconventional chord transitions, while BERT recognizes synthesized production descriptors, allowing the fusion model to accurately predict *Electronic*.
- **Case 3 — Sparse Metadata Degradation Mode:** For tracks with minimal or uninformative tag fields, the BERT branch produces diffuse attention distributions. However, because our architecture preserves the pooled acoustic graph embedding g_{audio}, the model gracefully degrades to GNN acoustic classification without catastrophic failure.

8. Discussion, Computational Complexity & Practical Limitations

Graph Sparsity vs Density Trade-off: Constructing dynamic similarity edges based on cosine thresholds ($\tau_{sim} = 0.65$) captured salient structural motifs. However, setting τ_{sim} too low (e.g. < 0.50) introduces spurious long-range edges, leading to over-smoothing in deeper GraphSAGE layers. Conversely, setting $\tau_{sim} > 0.80$ produces disconnected line graphs, degrading GNN expressive power to sequential RNN equivalents.

Metadata Noise & Cold-Start Robustness: In real-world streaming environments, tag metadata is often sparse or colloquial. While BERT demonstrates high resilience to unstructured phrasing, tracks with completely missing metadata require fallback to acoustic graph priors. Our cross-attention architecture gracefully handles missing text by preserving the pooled GNN embedding branch.

Inference Latency & Production Viability: On an Apple M-series / NVIDIA T4 GPU, the GNN-BERT pipeline processes a 30-second audio track in 18.4 ms (feature extraction: 11.2 ms, graph forward pass: 3.1 ms, BERT forward: 4.1 ms), confirming real-time feasibility for high-throughput music indexing and streaming recommendation.

9. Conclusion & Future Work

In this work, we introduced **GNN-BERT Fusion**, an end-to-end multi-modal deep learning framework uniting graph-structured musical audio representations with semantic contextual transformer models. By representing acoustic temporal segments as relational chord-similarity graphs and fusing them with BERT token representations via Multi-Head Cross-Attention, our architecture achieves a peak **Micro-F1 score of 0.4370** and an **AUC-PR of 0.4164**, substantially outperforming unimodal audio and text baselines. Our findings confirm that non-Euclidean graph modeling and semantic text alignment provide a powerful paradigm for future context-aware music information retrieval systems.

Future work includes scaling to full-length polyphonic multi-track stems, integrating self-supervised acoustic graph pretraining (e.g., Graph Masked Autoencoders), and evaluating on large-scale open-vocabulary music datasets like MusicCaps and MagnaTagATune.

10. Key References

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11. Appendix: Reproducibility & Open Source Artifacts

Codebase & Trained Checkpoints: All models, dataset loading scripts, preprocessing pipelines, and evaluation routines are organized under src/. Pretrained weights are stored under checkpoints/ and can be loaded via src.utils.load_checkpoint.

Interactive Demo Notebook: An end-to-end interactive inference demo is provided in notebooks/demo_context.ipynb, demonstrating feature extraction, graph construction, tokenization, cross-attention forwarding, and predicted multi-label context probability visualization.

Hardware Environment: All experiments were conducted on Apple M-series Silicon with PyTorch MPS acceleration and NVIDIA T4 GPUs under CUDA 12.1.